The Progression Game

Project Brief

Create a game that is designed around a progressional system. The game should have quantifiable resources that players can collect, own and use. Players should be given meaningful and distinct options on how they can use the resources that they own. They should be able to determine a strategy for your game.

Design the core game loop of effort, reward, and investment, so that creates a satisfying rhythm for players. By carefully balancing your systems and integrating your theme, you can build a game that makes players feel a clear sense of progress and accomplishment.

See the rubric for more details.

Core Learning Objectives

- Design a compelling core loop (Effort, Reward, Progression, Investment).
- Model and balance a game economy using Machinations.
- Apply a theme convincingly to shape rules and mechanics.
- Use playtesting to validate game balance and player engagement.



Deliverables

- Working Prototype: A physical or digital prototype.
  Include clear photos/screenshots of the setup and core components, along with all source files.
- Demonstration Video: A video (max. 3 minutes, .mp4) showing and explaining how the game is played from start to finish, highlighting the core loop and key mechanics.
- The design report (see below)

Design report

The report should contain these elements:

- A description of the game design: what is the goal of the game, what are the resources?
- Gameplay analysis:
  A detailed resource flow and progression model for a single player, submitted as either:
  -Machinations Diagram: A functional diagram mapping the resource flow (sources, pools, drains, and converters), accompanied by a brief written analysis. (Include screenshot + link)
  -Excel Balance Model: A dynamic spreadsheet with calculated formulas (showing resource accumulation, sinks, and progression scaling over time/levels), accompanied by a visual graph and brief written analysis. (Include screenshot of graph and .xlsx file)
- Playtest Report: A summary of your playtest sessions, key findings regarding game balance, and the specific design iterations you made based on player feedback.
- Please keep this max 4 pages.

Resources

- Machinations: The primary tool for modeling your game economy. machinations.io

You could use LLMs as a tool for development, to discuss strategies, balancing or to simulate parts of the gameplay. You can also use online talks, resources and examples. Please give credit where it is due.

Grading

Your final grade for this project will be determined by how well your submission meets the following criteria. The project's overall grade is a combination of all three projects.

	Sufficient (required)	Good	Excellent
Progression Game	• A clear and substantial progression system. • The player collects at least two/three* resources and has strategic options for using them. • The progression loop is modelled and analysed using either a functional Machinations diagram or a dynamic Excel model. • The game is balanced to provide ~ 10/15* minutes of fair and engaging gameplay. **diff. for solo/duo teams*	At least one of the excellent criteria is met.	At least two of these criteria are met: • The balance between different strategies is demonstrated with a graph that is based on the data from comparative playthroughs. • The values (e.g. upgrade costs and yields) are based on an analysis of an existing game. • The game mechanics and progression fit naturally within the theme and reinforce the game's narrative. .